How Movie Magic Brought Rotta the Hutt and Old-School Effects to 'The Mandalorian and Grogu'

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How do you make giant walking machines and a muscly space slug look real on screen? Hal Hickel, an **animation supervisor** at the special-effects company Industrial Light & Magic, or ILM, shared some secrets from "The Mandalorian and Grogu" at the View Conference in Turin, Italy, on Thursday.

Hickel said he kept asking one question: "What would Phil do?" He meant Phil Tippett, a **pioneer** of **stop-motion**, a technique where puppets are moved a tiny bit at a time and photographed frame by frame. Tippett's work on the original "Star Wars" movies inspired much of the new film.

For the opening battle, the team made the giant AT-AT walkers move even more slowly to show how heavy they are. A full-sized set even stretched through a walker's neck into its movable head. For the smaller AT-RT, animators studied ostriches, then used that movement to control a mechanical **rig** carrying the actors.

Rotta the Hutt, voiced by Jeremy Allen White, needed to move like a powerful fighter. ILM studied elephant seals and sumo wrestlers. But director Jon Favreau felt the first design "didn't feel Hutt-y enough," so the team changed Rotta's face and colors to look more like his father, Jabba. Because Rotta talks so much, the filmmakers had him speak English so younger viewers would not have to read lots of subtitles. One scene, with Grogu asleep on Rotta's chest, was a **tribute** to the animated film "My Neighbor Totoro."

The movie also includes a real **stop-motion** fight between two giant droids, made with Tippett's animators. Hickel even moved a puppet himself. He said doing **stop-motion** on a "Star Wars" film "will probably be forever the **pinnacle** of my career."

Word Treasure

animation supervisor -- The person who leads the team that makes characters and objects move on screen.

stop-motion -- A way of animating where objects are moved slightly and photographed one frame at a time.

pioneer -- One of the first people to develop a new idea or method.

rig -- A machine or frame built to hold and move people or equipment during filming.

tribute -- Something made to show respect or admiration for someone or something.

pinnacle -- The highest or best point of something.

Background you need

Visual effects, or VFX, are images created or changed by artists so that things impossible to film for real can appear on screen.

Industrial Light & Magic is a special-effects company that has worked on Star Wars films since the original movies.

Before computer graphics became common, many movie creatures were brought to life with stop-motion puppets photographed one frame at a time.

Today filmmakers often mix computer animation with real sets and machines so scenes feel more solid and believable.

Break it down

LEAD: ILM's Hal Hickel revealed how effects for 'The Mandalorian and Grogu' were made
GUIDING IDEA: 'What would Phil do?', honoring stop-motion pioneer Phil Tippett
+- WHO: Hal Hickel, Phil Tippett, director Jon Favreau
+- WHERE: View Conference in Turin, Italy
EXAMPLES: Slow, heavy AT-AT walkers; an AT-RT animated from ostrich movement; Rotta's redesign to look more like Jabba
TRIBUTES: A Totoro-style scene; a real stop-motion droid fight made with Tippett's animators
CLOSING: Hickel calls doing stop-motion on a Star Wars film the pinnacle of his career

Why it matters

It shows how filmmakers blend old-fashioned handmade techniques with modern computer effects to make movie worlds feel real.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Hal Hickel share these movie secrets?

- (A) On a TV talk show
- (B) At a theme park in Florida
- (C) At a Star Wars convention in Japan
- (D) At the View Conference in Turin, Italy

2. What question did Hickel keep asking himself?

- (A) What would Grogu do?
- (B) What would Phil do?
- (C) What would Jabba do?
- (D) What would George do?

3. Which animal did animators study for the AT-RT's movement?

- (A) Ostriches
- (B) Horses
- (C) Kangaroos
- (D) Elephants

4. Who voices Rotta the Hutt?

- (A) Jon Favreau
- (B) Jeremy Allen White
- (C) Hal Hickel
- (D) Phil Tippett

5. Why does Rotta speak English in the movie?

- (A) The actor could not speak Huttese
- (B) It was cheaper to film
- (C) He talks a lot, so younger viewers would not need many subtitles
- (D) Jabba spoke English too

6. Which film inspired the scene of Grogu asleep on Rotta's chest?

- (A) Toy Story
- (B) Spirited Away
- (C) Frozen
- (D) My Neighbor Totoro

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Hal Hickel, ILM animation supervisor: Guided the work by asking what Phil Tippett would do and called doing stop-motion on a Star Wars film the pinnacle of his career.

2. Jon Favreau, director: Felt Rotta's first design did not feel Hutt-y enough, leading to a redesign.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):